

WRIT7010

Assessment Item 1: Creative Writing Portfolio 1

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Including Weeks 7-15 Exercises; Week 10 Exercise Extended

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Extended Exercise: Week 10

Artist Statement

The extended exercise I chose was from week 10: **write a story or poem depicting the process of falling in love – use predominantly mental and relational then material (direct action) processes.** I chose this topic as an extension mainly because I consider myself relatively good at psychological description, and love has inspired me a lot. My inspiration for this assignment came from Olivia Rodrigo's song "Love is Embarrassing." However, when brainstorming, I realized that simply writing about the process is hard to meet the word count requirement and doing it well. So, I divide it into three perspectives. The next challenge was how to unify these perspectives without making them abrupt. This time, instead of constantly shifting angles within the text, I used the "Zhihu style," which is popular on the Chinese internet. This style can be basically understood as "Reddit style": Users ask questions on website, and others can invite or @ their friends to answer. Because it's in the Chinese context, there will be some uniquely descriptions, such as the school. I hope readers can enjoy reading it.

Question: Why is love so embarrassing? (Reply: 119,000)

Sort by Hot

Anonymous (29,856 kudos)

Thanks for the invite. I never actually thought love was something embarrassing. Love is beautiful, it makes my classmates kiss each other with joy. Love is courage, it makes the couple from the next class forget the teacher is right there and hug each other in the hallway. Unfortunately, neither of those love applied to me. I also wanted a passionate high school romance that would stun everyone around me. Unfortunately again, I fell in love with someone who doesn't exist. Ugh, as I'm writing this, the blinking cursor keeps moving back and forth in my document, and I just can't say it out loud. Even hiding behind anonymity, even type it. Fine. Never mind. I am the one decided to talk. Well, I fell in love with a character from a video game. His name is Arthur Morgan.

Anyone who played Red Dead Redemption 2 should familiar with him. He's the protagonist, and I am the nobody. Literally, nobody. I kept walking into invisible walls in my class, my voice never reaching anyone's ears. So I closed the zipper on my mouth and became the transparent person everyone kept passing through. I didn't know what I'd done wrong. I

couldn't find the answer. So I closed off my ears too, every word blocked out by the door of music. I couldn't manage to shut down my eyes or my heart, only because I thought he had a really nice smile.

An American cowboy who lived out west, forced by the changing times to move east, but how could he smile like that. A dirty but not ragged hat covering his messy blond hair, suspenders slung over his shoulders. UGH. You smell stink. I asked him why he hadn't gone to wash up yet, then brought him to a hotel. When I saw his robust, well-defined muscles, I had no choice but to turn my head away. *No, just one look. Just a single glance; it doesn't cost anything. Bath service? He needed it. I didn't. No thank you.* I complained his clothes were ugly, spending all the time since dropping out of school with this massive, bear-like man on hunts. The wounds that should have been added to my own arms appear on animals instead. *See, my fashion wasn't never wrong! This outfit suits you well!* I had him spin around, nodded with satisfaction. The lion-pelt cape made his shoulders look broad and his waist narrow. *Perfect. Congratulations on not being square.* He didn't say anything, just called me *good girl* when the horse broke into a gallop.

I didn't realize at the time that I liked him. I thought I just wanted him to be clean and handsome. It happened when my mood improved and I had to go back to school. The moment I closed my laptop I started counting. One minute, two minutes, three minutes. I spent twelve hours and fifty-six minutes away from him, wanting to fly off the fifth floor one hundred and fifty-six times, and being stopped one hundred and fifty-six times. I heard him murmuring softly in my ear, *good girl, good girl*. I told myself: be his good girl. Don't fall. Don't fly. When I got home I opened my laptop, the colorful glow is the only light source. I didn't care it, because I saw him sitting quietly with his hat tipped down over his face, asleep against the wall. My fitness watch alerted me that my heart rate was too high and asked if I was exercising. My face switched into heating mode. In the middle of winter I truly wanted to turn on the air-conditioner. I wondered — should I disturb him? Does he have a nice dream? Does him dream about me? I didn't even know if I was allowed to touch him. That night he slept there peacefully, missing sixty suns and sixty moons inside the game. I watched him quietly, until the sun rose behind my back.

That was when I realized I had, probably, maybe, possibly, perhaps, fallen in love with him. The moment I realized it, I deleted the entire game from my computer, trying to delete him from my life along with it. I got better, maybe. I didn't want to fly off any rooftops anymore. I didn't add any more cracks to my skin. I opened up my ears and my mouth again. Because I no longer had the mental space to care about anything else: every moment I was wondering, *what is he doing right now?* I hadn't opened the game. *Maybe he was sleeping? No, he could be on his way to rescue Dutch, or out hunting. What was he doing?* I wished he could talk to

me, wished I could know what he was up to. If I just opened my laptop, I could see him. If I just re-downloaded the game, I could see him. What was I even doing? If seeing him would make me the happiest person alive, why wasn't I opening the game?

Because he was in love with someone else. Because he would never love me. Because he existed in another world and I didn't. Still me. I'm not having a dissociative episode, I just know everything clearly. And that's exactly why I say love is such an embarrassing thing. I remember once, also online, I mentioned him to a stranger, said I really liked him. If I could date him I'd give my life for it. The stranger replied with one line: *Doesn't he already have someone he likes?* Smack. I heard the flimsy protective bubble cracks. The stranger wasn't satisfied with that, and added: *that's a video game character, it's impossible.* Yes, yes. A video game. He couldn't hear me. He's been in love with a girl for years. I even secretly, viciously hoped that girl would die, so I guess I'm not really his *good girl* after all. Whatever. He doesn't even know me. I could never stand in front of him and say, *hi, I've liked you for a long time, can you please stop liking her?* Even though I've rehearsed it in my head countless times, even though I've wished that lightning during a storm would strike me into his world like TV drama. It never works. The screen is the screen. I'm alive. He isn't.

I've always believed in reincarnation, some deity from some pantheon could bring me to another world, where we truly and genuinely exist for each other. So which direction should I face to make a wish, which direction to pray? I'll offer a bathtub of red water and flesh. Almighty god, can you make my wish come true?

Anonymous (22,034 kudos)

Nobody invited me. I decided to answer this question. My story isn't as dramatic as the first commenter. I always think that love is embarrassing. Maybe it connects with how I was raised: my family never told me they loved me. They only told me my grades weren't high enough or I hadn't done something well enough or that I wasn't allowed to do this or that. It's like everyone in my household had no idea about how to express love. Maybe this is the reason why they raised the ultimate avoidant: me.

When any conflict or problems happen on me, my first thought is to run. My life motto can be concluded as avoidance is not shameful and it's useful. So to me, love is deeply embarrassing. Saying it out loud is embarrassing. Falling for someone is embarrassing. The most embarrassing thing of all is finding that you fall for your friend, who is a girl. As for me, hello, nice to introduce myself, I am a girl too.

Before falling for her, I'd never liked anyone. Honestly, if it weren't for her, I always assumed

I didn't have those kinds of conventional desires. To me, no matter man or woman, everyone just a walking lump of flesh that would eventually die and decompose. What's appealing about flesh? It even not edible. If they were cooked by braised, or poached, or red-braised, I would genuinely fall in love deeply.

In that case, maybe she was like a beautiful but unappetizing plate of plain white-cut chicken for me. At first I only admired her, marveled at this beautiful chicken. However, there are many beautiful things and delicious foods in this world, I often looked away to appreciate others. Later I noticed that no matter how many beautiful things I looked at, my gaze always drifted back to that plate of white-cut chicken. Gradually, I stopped letting myself look at her directly, because I realized I'd developed a ferocious appetite. Why couldn't this plate of white-cut chicken be mine? Why couldn't she and I just merge into one?

Looking back, my feelings for her probably is traceable. She's always shining like a star. She could produce a brilliant piece of writing effortlessly and sometimes liked to write me a few small poems, saying they were dedicated to me, just mentioned it still can make me smile. In this technological age, finding someone who still likes to write letters is nearly impossible. Yet at my high school times, under strict closed-campus management that phones were banned, she kept writing to me in paper. Our friendship crossed the rivers and mountains of China to stay beside each other. Without her company, I might not have survived the nights sleeping on top of exam. I had those letters framed, hoping our friendship could be sealed under a layer of lacquer too. It'll never fade with time.

As it turned out, our friendship didn't fade at all: it became more passionate for me. I discovered I couldn't stand the men who hovered around her, couldn't stand it when she dropped me for some random guy, or well, maybe not random. I couldn't stand the empty seat across from me, the long chain of blue bubbles on the right side of our chat with only one short reply on the left, topics I'd thrown out met with nothing. I noticed she came home wearing the same outfit she'd left in the night before, and I silently resented him was a bad guy for not buying her a new set of clothes.

It was the night she introduced me to her boyfriend. Disaster. I couldn't even fake a smile. All I remember is the food tasted awful, the drinks tasted awful. She brought me home afterward, grumbling that I'd drunk too much and now she couldn't go back with him. If I didn't see double of her in that moment, I might grab her and say: *stop looking at other people, can't you? What's so good about men? Men don't understand anything.* But I wasn't that brave. I only grabbed the hem of her jacket, feeling like a stone in her way, crying and apologizing: *I'm sorry.* I'm sorry. Sorry for being such a burden. Sorry for being a stumbling block in the way of your happiness. Sorry for being such a hateful and troublesome grown-up. Sorry for being so useless and still want you stay by my side.

She heard my words, cupped my face in her hands, and looked at me with an expression I don't understand. I felt the room spinning, can't help but leaning into her hands, only noticing her perfume today smelled nice. She looked at me very seriously, unbothered by my mix of snot and tears on her hands, and apologized. She said it was her fault that she'd been neglecting me lately, I was never in the way. Through my tears I watched her multiply into four or five versions of herself, and broke into the first smile of that entire day, flooded with relief. There was a light dawn on me. I just want her eyes focus on me and only me. I just wanted her and only her. I am a lesbian.

Anonymous (15,698 kudos)

Thanks for the invite. My notifications exploded the second I got off the plane. Apparently in my friends' opinion, my relationship really is that embarrassing. Honestly, I got it. I never bring him around when I meet them, so that I don't have to be the meat in the sandwich that is constantly squished from both sides. But since I've been invited to answer this, I will introduce my situation and let you be the judge.

In terms of looks, he's decent enough, which is why when I first met him I skipped right over the crowd of guys around him and spotted him first. He's 185 cm, the kind of height that makes you look really good bringing him out. He has curly hair (I'd like to call him frizzy black cat sometimes) and two narrow, slightly squinting eyes, saved only by a bridge connecting and dividing the land, otherwise it would be an unremarkable face. Because his eyes are so small, I often can't tell what expression he's making or what he's thinking. He's also not photogenic, and always reluctant to take pictures with me.

His problem is: his social skills were critically underdeveloped. Maybe because he's a nerd in the conventional sense: top of his class since childhood, currently a PhD student, he could barely be a hot nerd. However, he'll cut me off mid-sentence and launch into his own monologue without missing a beat. Sometimes I feel like his ego could blow the walls off our apartment. He also has strong opinions about my love of anime and celebrities, strong, negative opinions, which lead to a cold war week.

When we go on dates or when I meet up with friends, I always pick the right dress and spend an hour on my makeup. For him, it's just a matter of changing clothes or not. The whole meeting was even more of a disaster. My friend gave him a once-over, scanning his outfit with barely concealed disdain, and I interrupted her just before she made any mean commentary: *he's just comfortable around you*, I said, *that's why he dressed casually*. She rolled her eyes so hard only the whites were showing and I could only laugh it off. But before

I could even finish smoothing things over, he opened his mouth and drove her out of the room. He spent a full twenty minutes criticizing the fashion industry which she works in, until it sounded like the worst career choice and she should quit it.

In my friends' eyes, I'm a perfectly good cabbage that got rooted by a pig, and a spineless one at that. The number of times they've urged me to break up with him probably exceeds the number of days in a year. Eventually I learned to play dumb whenever the topic of dating, relationships came up. When cornered with no escape, I'd turn my head slightly and say in a small voice: *still*.

Why still together? Why not break up? They keep asking the same question. But maybe if I had the chance to do it all over again, I'd still choose to stay in this awkward, embarrassing relationship. The truth and the reason is simple. I just find it very hard to say out loud. Because it feels too small, even not worth mentioning. It also makes me feel like a hopelessly lost person, someone clinging to such a tiny little lifeline and refusing to let go. Whatever. This is the internet, and I'm anonymous. I'll say it. The reason I'm still willing to stay in this exhausting, entirely undignified relationship is because he will always welcome me home.

Yes. That's it. That's how small it is. Some of you are probably reading this thinking: *you continue this relationship for such trivial thing? Isn't it just basic? Just admit you're a devoted little housewife and be done with it.* But for me, coming home at twelve after working overtime, what I want isn't someone to talk to (my voice has already filed a resignation letter after a full day of meetings), and it's not passionate sex (I just want to fall face-first into bed). What I want is to open the door, a lit-up apartment, a hot meal waiting, my favorite milk tea on the side, and him, awkwardly blaming me: *why are you home so late today*. Okay. Just picturing that scene right now I'm willing to forgive him for throwing a dark shirt in with the light laundry this morning. Maybe I am the Greek god of going soft, the first commenter should make her wishes to me.

Recent comments

User sdhiaun12ao

Came back in 2026. Top three comments were written by the same person. Someone tracked it down, click the link.

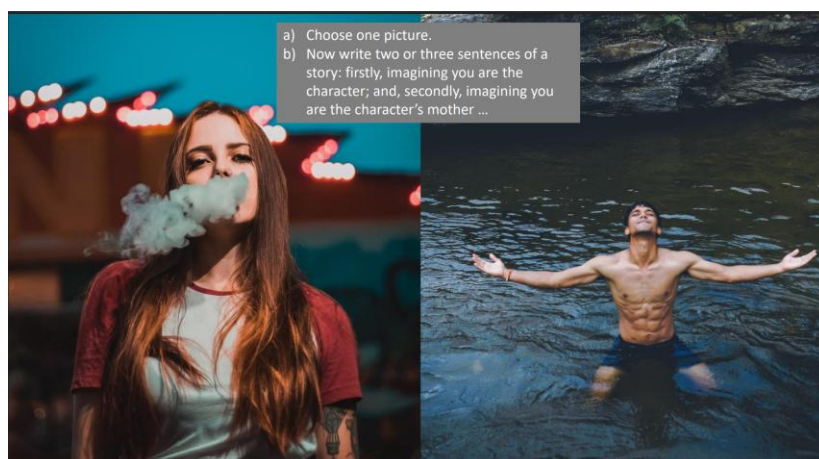
Week 7

1. Say the most honest and true thing you can say in one sentence - the thing that matters most to you. Speak directly from your soul, forget everything you should say, everything that's 'clever', everything that's 'correct'; forget your 'public self', the one you perform, forget decoration ... **Put the sentence in bold.** Then write appx 150-300 words / 1-2 pgs, to follow that first statement, attempting always a 'naïve style'.

Perhaps jealousy is my true nature. At first, I didn't know what jealousy was. Those two words are so difficult to write in Chinese; I hadn't even learned such obscure words in elementary school. I was simply looking at the thin, small arms and fair skin next to me, hearing that girl's clear, pleasant laughter. I wanted it, I wanted it too. I wanted that beautiful long hair and tall stature. I wanted to be welcome, not short and chubby, not shy and boring. What would being dark-skinned bring me? Laughter? They said they couldn't find me at night, and I felt like my face was about to burn me to ashes. I didn't know I had this superpower before. What's it called? Burning? Explosion? Firing? I decided call myself "Firewoman" and told them I have superpowers. Then I'd be popular. I could even help Grandma burn woods.

I remember that day I announced myself as "Firewoman" and everyone's laughter was so loud I wanted to grab the pen on the table and poke my ears. Why could I still hear it? Why did I start burning again? Why didn't anyone believe me? Mama, did I do anything wrong that made you born me like this? I don't want this power. I just want to be a pretty and happy girl.

Week 9



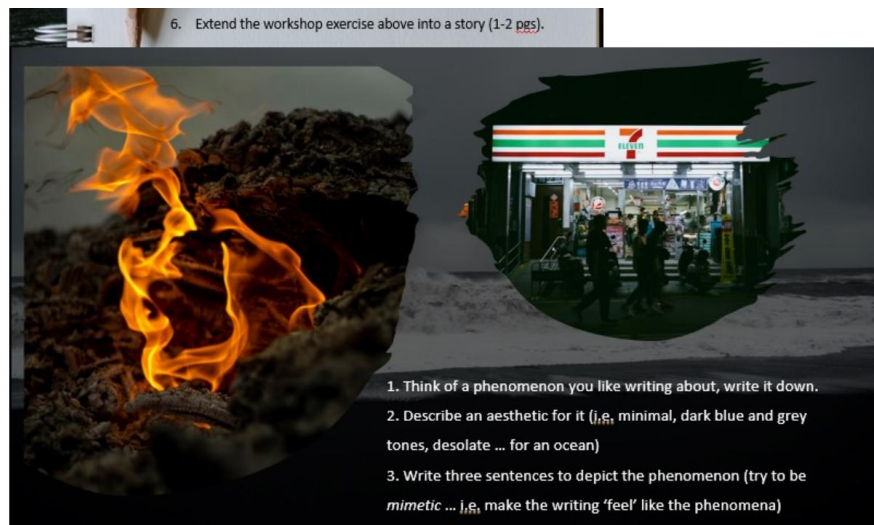
Boring. School is so boring. Sally sat by the roadside, pulling out cigarettes she'd secretly brought from home. She'd seen the pack just as she was rushing to school while her dropout brother was glued to the ball game. Sally glanced at him, then at the desk—pen and the cigarette had never looked so similar. She deftly mixed them together and slipped them into her pocket, smiling: "I'm off to school", leaving with the fading sound of the game.

Anyway, free cigarettes, it'd be a waste not to smoke them. Sally patted her smoking buddy next to her, offering him a cigarette in exchange for a free light. But then a familiar lighter appeared before her, and a similar face peeked out from hat, wrinkled eyes staring at her. The cigarette didn't catch the flame; instead, that woman took it. She lit it, burning nicotine, inhaling, exhaling smoke rings.

"You smoke now? Whose cigarettes? Peter?" she asked. Sally said nothing, frowning and turning her head round, took the lighter from her hand, and lit another one for herself. She saw Sally choke on the bitter taste, her face contorted in a grimace so much like the baby she had been over a decade ago. She throws away more and more cigarettes and her belly become bigger and bigger. Sometimes, she hesitated to look up as she passed a newsstand, or stopping at a street corner to take in the lingering nicotine. A hard kick from uterus wakes her up; she covered her mouth and nose and ran away.

She has interest in cigarettes is it because of her chain-smoking mother? She thoughts.

Week 11



January 17th, a man called Neji Kokuto put down his pen, decided to die.

Suicide, what a beautiful thing it is in our country's culture. Authors seeking death is quite usual; Dazai committed suicide with his mistress (even though he failed so many times), then Mishima committed seppuku (what a painful and inhumane way to die), and Neji Kokuto chose the sea. Our country truly is a country that loves suicide. Neji twirled his pen, ink spilling onto the blank manuscript paper—this is the first marks it had received in over ten days. Even the ink has more inspiration than I have; damn it, I can't write a single word. I might never write again. Neji remembered asking Kisa on his way home for New Year's, what she would do if she couldn't act anymore. "Struggle and hard-working". She was as resilient as he had predicted. That was one of her many talents. If it weren't for the reluctance, if it weren't for the lingering thoughts of her, I really wanted to...

"Slap!"

How could you think of taking her to die? Neji Kokuto truly become a hopeless lover boy, he couldn't help but thinking about her even in suicide. This cycle had become his norm for the past ten days and it seemed to be getting worse. The school performance date was constantly chasing him, while he hid on the shore, trying to scan through his brain for any usable inspiration. However, every folder was filled with thoughts of "Tachibana Kisa". Thankfully, he saw her before he died, which was a small comfort. That's what he thought when he saw the sea. He'd always felt an immense attraction from the sea. Perhaps it was because his father perished here, who had lost his talent because of a woman. Every year on the anniversary of his father's death, Neji would return to this beach to lay a bouquet of flowers. He can sense his father was calling him every time: "Kokuto, come with me."

Father, what does the sea feel like? Clothes must be heavy when they get wet, but the steps towards the sea are light. I'm finally here. The deeper he goes, the more he loses his strength. First, the lower body frozed, then the fingers could only tremble physiologically. At this point, it was impossible to go any further. Fear become stronger than death itself, but the monster wouldn't let its prey escape. The sea wouldn't let go resources that willingly walked into its embrace. The sound of the waves crashing on the shore was the countdown to life, carrying sand and chunks of flesh, sucking everything it could reach into the body. Eyes and mouth became open shells, filled with salty liquid. It's just a pity I couldn't tell her the sea is black, and not beautiful at all.

Week 12

1. Write a story or poem in which, like Lopez, you incorporate language from a completely different genre/source (it might even be 'realia' (i.e. from the real world – e.g. prayers from a prayer book). (1-2 pgs).

Profile

Hello, stranger. If you can see my name, make sure you pronounce it correctly — I am Kazura, not Zura. Nice to meet you. The fact that you can see my profile suggests we are highly compatible. I will also make sure to pronounce your name correctly. I am currently a government civil servant, though the bureaucracy is insufferably bloated — every day I organize my colleagues to negotiate with parliament, demanding they streamline procedures and reduce our burden. This dating app was downloaded at the insistence of my friends. I had no choice. They always say my tastes are unusual and that I will never find the right person without going on one of these things. But my requirements are not particularly high. I simply hope, dear lady, that you are married, divorced, or have lost your husband. If you meet any one of the above conditions and are currently grieving the departure of a husband, please do not hesitate to contact me — guiding you through this difficult time is my responsibility and my mission. Additionally, if possible, I hope you enjoy animals. I recently adopted a large duck who is extremely adorable, and I am also planning to get a cat or a dog. Soft little paws are truly one of humanity's greatest pleasures and sources of comfort.

Reply

User shidawbnsdnksbuabzc: Are you Japanese?

Kazura: How did you know I am ニホンジン? Our country is wonderful, apart from the government being absolutely corrupt. I have already organized the public to demand simplified administrative procedures, but they never listen to me — especially the Shinsengumi. We are all acquaintances, their captain is friends with my brother, and yet they are always chasing me around. Though I will say their captain is a man of integrity — everyone is just doing their job, I suppose. Are you a foreigner? You are welcome to visit. I live right next to Kabukicho, so if you ever come to Tokyo please be sure to drop by. I can take you to the gates of parliament, and you can also meet my duck — he has recently learned to follow me when I walk, which shows remarkable intelligence. My next goal is to teach him the hiragana syllabary. I am certain he can learn it. Oh, and I gave him a new name: Elizabeth. Cute, isn't it.

User shidawbnsdnksbuabzc: [Seen]

Week 15

1. Write a poem or short story based on a famous/favourite painting instead! (you can choose with Homer's *Summer Night* or Bocklin's *Island of the Dead*) (note: please post the picture as well)

"You know it, it's wind." I take her arm and pull the hair on her face back by the wind. She put her hand on my shoulder, hold it and move quietly, dancing with the music brought by the wind. She sings the harmony in front of me. One step, two steps, three steps. Oops. She smiled and said it hurt so much. My face turn to sunset. I didn't dare to look at her, wanted to put away my clumsy feet and hands. But she grabbed me and raised my face. The faded sunset shone on her and the sea one after another. Is that the sun? No, it's not. Sun was pushed away by clouds. It is the sea. I muttered to myself. It turned out to be a beautiful sea.